Chapter 15

Be Patient, Be Kind

Your kindness usually slips first over something small. She says something with an edge about the things that need doing. You feel it land. You're tired, and before you've decided anything, your answer is already in your mouth.

In an ordinary day, your warmth gets tested three ways. Meet hostility with kindness. Meet frustration with patience. Meet disconnection with warmth.

Meet hostility with kindness.

My family has a word for a comment with an edge. We call it a zing, and there are so many in a day it's hard to keep count. A zing is a little slight, a cutting remark. It's a critique, only small.

I didn't handle them well. Every little critique from her was met with an equal or escalated response. I had no patience, I didn't let things go, I wasn't kind. Frankly, neither was she.

Arguing styles drift over time, almost like evolution. You use what rewards. I'd feel tired. I'd feel frustrated that immediately she was giving me things to do. Her words felt like she was calling me lazy.

One kind of zing comes on Saturday mornings, on busy weekends. My wife wakes up with a jam-packed agenda for Saturday and Sunday to get a lot of things done. I'm tired and want to relax, or I'm just sitting down talking to the kids. She's asking for the status of things that need to be done. And sometimes she'll say something like, "We don't have time to just lay around and not do stuff." Or: "There's an infinite amount of work to get done. Just look around. I shouldn't have to tell you what to do." You've probably heard your own version of those lines.

I used to take those lines personally. Over time I realized a line like that is more a sign of how stressed and overworked she is.

When you hear a line like that, you can ask one of two different questions. The first is about you. If it sounds like she's calling you lazy, ask yourself, "Is that truly the case?" If it is, fix it. If it isn't, let the remark go.

The second question is about her: what does the remark tell you about how she feels? Most of the time, the remark says less about you than it seems. It's an outward manifestation of how she's feeling on the inside. Maybe she isn't in a good mental state. Maybe she's frustrated about something. Either way, you don't have to be offended. That reading is for you to keep, not something to say to her. If a remark still hurts you every time, Chapter 11 covers how to raise it with her.

What changed for me came slowly, through experience. I started asking: who has the strength to de-escalate? Somebody has to be calm. Somebody has to be patient. Somebody has to be the one that's romantic and kind. Someone has to be the one that brings the warmth into the relationship.

In his study of anger, Seneca wrote: "Does a man get angry? Do you on the contrary challenge him with kindness. Animosity, if abandoned by one side, forthwith dies; it takes two to make a fight." (*De Ira* II.34, Basore trans.) "Forthwith" means at once. A zing rarely turns into a fight unless you send one back.

So instead of zinging her back, I do two things. I roll up my sleeves and start helping. Then I give her a hug, tell her what I see her carrying, and take a little time to find out if I can make her day lighter.

We have a saying in our house: "Never be the worst part of somebody's day." It's a spot check, a way to make sure we're not unkind. A sharper answer is the quickest way to be the worst part of her day.

Meet frustration with patience.

Feeling fed up drives faster responses and more intense reactions. You may know that from your own arguments. I know it from ours. The ironic part is that ours weren't about any one topic. I was fed up with how we argued.

She gets fed up too, and on a weekend with a mountain of work ahead, so do you. When she's tired, you may be tired too. That's two tired people. Patience is your choice to be kind anyway.

Patience lives in the gap Chapter 1 named, between her remark and your reply. Seneca put it in one line: "The best corrective of anger lies in delay." (*De Ira* II.29, Basore trans.) You don't have to answer in the first second. You can roll up your sleeves first.

Answering every zing is checkers. Chess means keeping your eye on the long game. When I let the zings go and give her kindness instead, it has an incredible impact on changing the tone and the mood of the entire house. I would rather have a good night of happiness with my wife than try to answer each exchange. You get to decide which of those you're after. I tell people, "Would you rather be right? Or would you rather be married?"

None of this is surrender. Letting a zing go doesn't mean doing whatever she says. This is my own advice to myself, learned through experience. It comes down to Chapter 1's question, asked in the moment: Are you being the best husband possible right now, at this moment, irrespective of what she is doing?

Meet disconnection with warmth.

Disconnection often happens when everyone is busy and there's nothing but a mountain of work ahead of you. It gets even worse when other family members have friction between them. If my wife is frustrated with one of her siblings on the phone, or with one of our children, that then leads to

disconnection with us. Sometimes I have to see that as not a verdict on me, just a sign that she is feeling strained. Whenever I take the bait, I add another layer, and then everybody's pulled into the vortex.

Warmth is how you stay out of the vortex and pull her out of it. You can be home all weekend and still not be kind. As I see it, being kind is different than just being there. It's trying your best to make someone's day better.

For me, that's a foot rub when she's had a long day. It's taking over a chore that's usually hers. It's letting her talk about her day, because it's a kindness to let her speak and get things off her chest.

Why is the chore kind? It's an act of service, her love language. And it's kind because these are normally things that she does, and I'm taking chores and work off of her plate. I'm doing something that shows I want to make her life better. You know which chores are usually hers in your house.

A 2022 study by Gordon and colleagues looked at housework. People who did more of it, and felt the split was unfair, tended to be less satisfied in the relationship. The exception was people who felt appreciated by their partner. The study wasn't about husbands who help, but I read it as a reason for you to do both: help her, and let her know you see her.

When you are the sun, people come to you to feel good. In Book I of *Meditations*, the Roman emperor Marcus Aurelius lists what he learned from the people who shaped him. Sextus is one of them. Marcus wrote that Sextus "never showed anger or any other passion, but was entirely free from passion, and also most affectionate." (*Meditations* I.9, Long trans.) The Greek behind "most affectionate" belongs to the word *philostorgia*, family love. "Free from passion" here means Sextus wasn't ruled by anger or upset. Sextus was calm and warm at once.

That pairing is compassion in your home: you see her load, you act on it, and you stay steady yourself. She deserves kindness every day, always, even when

she’s at her lowest. You don’t wait for her to earn it.

The best part.

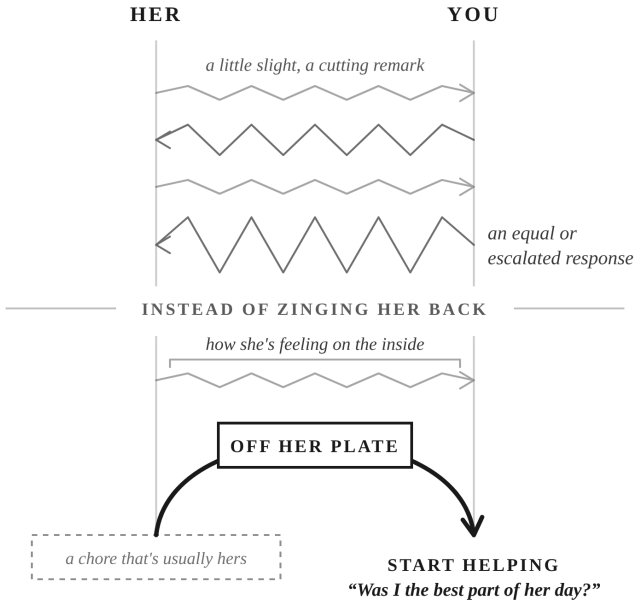
Our saying has a second half: “You can be the best part of somebody’s day.” If you asked yourself whether you’re the best part of her day, the honest answer might be no.

So ask yourself, each day: “Was I the best part of her day?”

For a long time I answered every zing. I should have been asking whether I was the best part of her day.

When the next zing lands, roll up your sleeves before you open your mouth.

KINDNESS ANSWERS THE ZING



Roll up your sleeves before you open your mouth.

Chapter 15 — Be Patient, Be Kind

Mechanism: Meet hostility with kindness, frustration with patience, disconnection with warmth

The idea in one sentence: When your wife's day turns sharp, meet hostility with kindness, frustration with patience, and disconnection with warmth, and ask yourself each day whether you were the best part of her day.

In an ordinary day, your warmth gets tested three ways. The first is a zing, a small, cutting remark. When one lands, ask whether it's true about you. If it is, fix it. If it isn't, let it go. Then ask what it tells you about how she feels. Seneca's point is that it takes two to make a fight, so whether a zing becomes one is up to your reply. The second test is frustration. When you're both tired and fed up, patience is your choice to be kind anyway. You don't have to answer in the first second. Roll up your sleeves first. The third test is disconnection, when she's strained by a busy day or by friction with someone else. See it as a sign of strain, not a judgment on you. Being home isn't the same as being kind. Take a chore that's usually hers off her plate, and let her talk. Never be the worst part of her day, and aim to be the best part.

Lesson: Kindness, patience, and warmth are choices you make in your reply, even when you're tired too.

Challenge: The next time a zing lands, roll up your sleeves and start helping before you say a word, and that night ask yourself whether you were the best part of her day.

PRACTICE

1. **Reactive.** When she makes a small, cutting remark, don't send a sharper one back. Ask yourself whether it's true. If it is, fix it. If it isn't, let it go. Then ask what the remark tells you about how she's feeling.
2. **Reactive.** When you're both fed up and a sharp comment comes about the things that need doing, don't answer in the first second. Start helping first. Then give her a hug, tell her what you see her carrying, and ask what would make her day lighter.
3. **Proactive.** Every day, ask yourself whether you were the best part of her day. Take over one chore that's usually hers, or give her time to talk about her day.